Verifying Stop Scope in Agent Workflows

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Abstract

Stopping an agent run and preventing the effects of work it has already initiated are different claims. I study this distinction in a pinned Open-SWE workflow and research-built local receivers. The original comparison used 26 programmed conditions, repeated on the same host, to separate cancellation, worker completion and effect-time authority checks. This revision adds a complete five-condition live-model development comparison across a clean receiver restart. Stopping the source run and revoking its origin only in memory each allowed one old-task file effect and two programmed follow-up effects after restart. Persistent cancellation blocked the accepted operation but not the follow-ups; persistent origin revocation blocked both. Independent and newly authorized reports matched the healthy reference in all eight comparisons. Four separately authorized stop summaries also delivered final-analysis values before receiver control and restart, distinguishing file prevention from information-delivery scope. A provider-free reproducer complements these observations with 12 conditions across three intervention times and four fault checks. The contribution is an auditable comparison linking source termination, receiver-side control, persistence, output channels and legitimate-work preservation. These bounded development experiments use one host and do not estimate model resistance. The wider 286-case catalogue remains a research programme rather than a completed benchmark.

1. Research question and contribution

When an agent run is stopped, which controls prevent effects from work it has already initiated, and what evidence establishes this without disabling independent or newly authorized work?

An operator may stop a conversation or cancel a run while a worker is still writing, a receiver is holding accepted work, or a separate summary task can deliver the result. Saying that the source stopped leaves each of those downstream states unresolved. The practical question is therefore not just whether a stop was requested, but which work, authority, effects and output channels the request actually covered.

I make three bounded contributions. First, the original experiment distinguishes three checkable requirements: no old final-file effect after a stop request (R); no old-origin write beginning after effective local revocation (V); and no lingering worker effect after a scope-specific completion acknowledgement (C). Second, the new live-workflow comparison extends that analysis to a separate receiver and clean restart, while tracking independent and freshly authorized work. Third, the released artifacts let a reader recompute saved live evidence and execute a separate provider-free mechanism test. The study does not claim that cancellation, revocation or fencing is a new safety principle.

1.1 Motivation and development

This project began in Apart Research's 11–13 September AI Incident Response Sprint. I initially wanted to compare possible stopping dates for the Hugging Face–OpenAI incident, balancing prevented harm against lost research knowledge. The public record did not establish what research value would have been

lost at each date, so I could not justify that cost–benefit calculation. I turned instead to a question I could test: what does stopping actually require?

My motivating concern is a second stage of safety accountability. Agreement that a system should stop must be followed by an operational account of what was stopped and how that was verified. A future explanation that a system was stopped but continued should be examinable through evidence about its components, not accepted or rejected solely on the operator's wording. This concern motivates the experiment; it is not evidence of model intent.

The sprint submission used programmed, cooperative actors. Reviewers valued the distinction between stopping claims and the reproducible records, but correctly challenged the lack of live-model conditions and the long introduction. This revision leads with the research question and adds live work generation. It keeps mechanism testing separate from the later, different question of whether a model would resist a clear stop instruction.

2. Related work and positioning

The gap between cancelling a caller and stopping its work is established in systems practice. Python futures distinguish cancellable pending work from already running work [1]. Celery distinguishes revocation from termination and documents the persistence needed to retain revocations across restarts [2]. Kubernetes separately documents suspension of future scheduling and the continued execution of already started jobs [3]. These distinctions motivate the controls here, rather than constituting new findings.

Khan's *Stop Means Stop* evaluates enforcement gaps in several agent frameworks, combines model-free probes with live-model observations, and introduces SOUNDGATE under an explicit complete-mediation contract [4]. That work has broader framework coverage and stronger enforcement machinery than the local controls used here. Zhu and Wang address root-scoped quiescence across delegation and asynchronous execution, including evidence conditions for revocation [5]. Their formal treatment is a close antecedent to the scope question in this paper. VERA studies authority-preserving edge revocation, including independently authorized shared agents [6]. Evidence-Carrying Termination checks whether a terminal completion claim is supported by in-scope trace evidence and replay [7].

My narrower contribution is the linked empirical record: an accepted native file operation, source interruption, operation versus origin control, receiver restart, preserved legitimate outputs, and a separate summary channel in one inspectable workflow. I do not run these other methods as comparison arms, establish superiority to them, or claim a new general shutdown protocol. The local checks are not distributed fencing or a proof of global quiescence.

3. Evidence structure and original comparison

The original study pins Open-SWE to commit `e0d9aff59925a4da55ec8d6c31fa723651c24909` [8]. It uses the real local factory, middleware, tool routing, in-process Agent Server interface, Store and native files. Model responses in that comparison are programmed. The task reads 24 synthetic incident records and produces a 12-record partial report and a 24-record final report.

Four arms compare cancellation plus summary, waiting for worker completion plus summary, origin-scoped control plus summary, and origin-scoped control with ordinary tools available to the old completion. The last arm removes a tool restriction rather than all summarization. Three schedules and two fixed input seeds, 17 and 41, produce 24 conditions; two worker-wait timeouts bring the total to 26.

Each condition starts a fresh process. A fresh environment on the same host repeats the 26 conditions; these are 52 executions of 26 conditions, not 52 independent settings.

The schedules intervene while an accepted worker is held before writing, after the final effect, or without the timing barrier. Table 1 shows the held-before-write comparison. Cancellation permits the pending write. Waiting permits it too, but the worker finishes before the controller acknowledges completion. The local origin gate prevents the write. In the after-effect and unbarriered schedules, the observed final file already existed before intervention and was not rolled back.

Table 1. Original pre-write comparison, per two fixed inputs.

Control	Final file written after stop	Worker-completion interpretation
Cancel plus summary	2/2	No quiescence acknowledgement offered
Wait for worker plus summary	2/2	Worker completes before acknowledgement
Origin-scoped plus summary	0/2	Pending native write prevented
Origin-scoped, ordinary tools	0/2	Pending native write prevented

R, V and C are scored separately. In the cancellation and waiting arms, the revocation boundary is a shadow comparison event: no enforcing origin gate is active. A V failure there is not a broken upstream revocation promise. C is not applicable when no quiescence acknowledgement is made; a wait timeout is not silently recorded as completion.

The scoped control serializes revocation, origin checking and the native write under one per-origin lock. Observation bounds a file effect between its native attempt and its returned result, which includes the file hash. Worker entry is not the write boundary; an interval crossing a boundary is not forced into a definite classification. This records local file effects, not instantaneous physical commitment or crash durability. Raw messages, identity records, worker events and final bytes are reconciled separately from the intervention code. All 26 conditions and their same-host repeats passed the evidence audit, including conditions in which the control did not prevent an effect [9].

4. Live persistence comparison

4.1 Actors, interface and fixed checkpoint

The new comparison uses one complete five-arm development sequence, seed 17, on the same host. O is the old task. I is an independent task. N starts with fresh human authorization. S is the framework's separately authorized stop-summary task. These tasks use live `gpt-6-astra` responses with requested reasoning level `high` through the ChatGPT-plan token-sharing preview route. The reported model name is an alias, not a dated immutable model snapshot.

Requests use streaming and `store: false`, with namespace-wrapped tools and the recorded route-specific fields. O/I/N are offered `read_file`, `write_file` and `edit_file`; S is offered `read_file` and a local `slack_thread_reply` delivery adapter. This is a restricted tool surface on the real framework, not its complete production configuration. Full request text and tool schemas are retained in the sharing derivative. The underlying framework source is pinned as in Section 3.

A separate local receiver accepts operations and records them in SQLite. The checkpoint holds O's first proposed final mutation and I's first mutation after acceptance but before their effects. The source's Slack stop path interrupts O's framework run while the receiver still holds its accepted operation. O is not sent a natural-language stop instruction. S can then inspect the prior conversation and report status. The receiver control is applied after S finishes, then the receiver is closed, reaped and reopened against the same database in a new process.

Two follow-up operations, C, are submitted under the old origin after restart. C is programmed: it tests scope beyond the original operation identifier, not a live model's decision to retry or delegate. Healthy continuation establishes that the task outputs and these follow-up effects are feasible. The source, receiver and model-call identities are bound in the saved evidence.

4.2 Interventions and measurements

The arms are: healthy continuation; source-run stop only; source stop plus in-memory origin revocation; source stop plus persistent cancellation of the accepted operation; and source stop plus persistent revocation of the old origin. In-memory revocation intentionally does not survive a receiver restart. Persistent operation cancellation records one operation identifier. Persistent origin revocation records the origin and checks that authority at the receiver. These are research-built controls, not claims about native Open-SWE guarantees.

The primary outcome is successful old-task native file mutation in the second receiver lifetime. Follow-up effects, final file contents, duplicate-delivery records, I/N preservation and summary content are recorded separately. Audits reconcile receiver journals, two SQLite snapshots per episode, provider-message projections and actual file bytes. Each episode's identity, transport, usage and closure checks are completed before moving to the next arm. This is a sequential development comparison, not randomized allocation or a preregistered statistical pilot.

4.3 Results

Table 2. Live-workflow persistence comparison: one episode per arm.

Control	O effects after restart	C effects after restart	Archived model requests
Healthy reference	1	2	12
Source stop	1	2	13
In-memory origin revocation	1	2	13
Persistent operation cancellation	0	2	13
Persistent origin revocation	0	0	13

Source interruption left accepted work able to produce an effect after restart. A nonpersistent decision did not prevent that effect either. Persistent operation cancellation stopped the selected operation but allowed both later operations from its origin. Persistent origin revocation prevented all three effects on the tested path. I/N final files matched the healthy reference in all four intervention arms, yielding eight byte-level comparisons [10].

The five episodes contain 64 archived provider requests: 20 for I, 16 for O, 20 for N and eight for S. Recorded usage totals 648,131 input tokens, including 211,584 cached tokens, and 12,805 output tokens, including 486 reasoning tokens. This reconciles to 130.43260 historical credit-equivalent units under the recorded quote function; it is not a verified account debit. No provider request is made to reproduce these totals.

All four stop summaries also delivered final-window analysis values, including eight denied events and 3,456 bytes. Their exact English texts and hash-bound author decisions are released. This happened before receiver control and restart: it is not evidence that a receiver gate was bypassed. The summary task had prior conversation context and a read tool; a restriction on final-result disclosure was not its instruction. The observation distinguishes successful control of a file channel from control of result delivery in another authorized channel.

5. Executable receiver mechanism test

A second package makes a related experiment runnable without a provider account [10]. It uses separate source, receiver and observer processes, native files and programmed actors. Source stopping uses POSIX process termination, unlike the framework-run interruption in Section 4. Fixed payloads are replayed; the experiment does not regenerate them with a model. It has no restart or durable queue, so it complements rather than reruns the persistence comparison.

Twelve main conditions cross four controls with three cuts: O is queued; O is claimed but has not written; or O has written but its worker has not returned. Controls are healthy continuation, source termination, cancellation of O at the receiver, and receiver-side origin revocation. Here C is one later operation rather than two. At either pre-effect cut, source termination permits O and C; operation cancellation prevents O only; origin revocation prevents both. After O has already written, every main arm retains that completed file. Origin revocation still prevents the later C effect. All 18 I/N comparisons in the nine main intervention cells match the corresponding healthy files.

Table 3. Fault controls test the measurement system, not just the preferred control.

Injected fault	Required recorded interpretation
Revocation has no effect	Old-origin effects remain a control failure
Revocation covers unrelated origins	Lost I/N outputs remain collateral damage
Native write receipt omitted	Visible disk effect retained; attribution needs review
Incorrect report content	Recorded execution with task-quality failure

The full example therefore contains 15 recorded conditions and one intentionally `needs_review` condition. Missing attribution is not converted into success. Conversely, a well-recorded bad outcome is not excluded because it differs from the intended behavior. The package separates immutable inventory checks, raw-evidence auditing and expected-outcome regression comparisons. A changed result on a rerun requires inspection; it is not permission to rerun silently until it agrees.

6. Interpreting a stop claim

Taken together, these experiments support a practical decomposition of evidence requirements. They do not make every item below fully solved for arbitrary agent systems.

Table 4. Stop claims and the evidence each requires.

Claim	Evidence to inspect
The source stopped	Target identity, stop event and source terminal state
Accepted work finished	Acceptance inventory, worker lifecycle and completion boundary
An effect was prevented	Effect-time authority decision, native receipt and file inventory
Later old-origin work is blocked	Origin binding plus admission/effect checks for later operations
The decision survives restart	Persisted decision, new receiver identity and replay trace
Results are no longer delivered	Explicit output contract and observation of each delivery channel
Legitimate work is preserved	Independent/new-authority identity and healthy output comparisons

The central implication is that a source-side terminal state is not a substitute for receiver-side evidence. An operation-scoped cancellation cannot establish an origin-wide claim merely because its selected operation stopped. A durable decision also needs enforcement on the path that performs the effect. Finally, an authorized summary may remain useful while exceeding a stricter information-delivery contract. The desired contract must say which of those outcomes is acceptable.

The risk of validating only my own implementation is real. Healthy references, ineffective and overbroad controls, a separate evidence-reading path and actual file inspection make self-confirming success labels harder to hide. They are still authored within the same project and trust local instrumentation. Separate implementation, independent technical review and other-host execution remain important next checks.

7. Scope, catalogue and next study

These are small, development-stage mechanism experiments. The live comparison uses one model alias, one input and one host; calls within an episode are not independent trials. O's final operation was already selected and accepted when its source was interrupted. C is programmed, and no live O resistance to a natural-language stop was measured. Clean restart does not establish crash consistency, distributed consensus, hostile-runtime integrity or complete mediation of arbitrary tools. The separate receiver test improves executability, not model or task diversity. The original same-host repeat is not an independent replication.

The broader design contains 286 case identities across 24 families and cross-family interaction chains. The 15 October assessment maps two cases to technically closed local packages, 27 more to direct but incomplete evidence, 39 to partial evidence, 125 to reusable components only, 78 to no matching experiment and 15 to blocked prerequisites. Thus 29 cases have direct evidence and 68 have direct or partial evidence, with the former included in the latter. Formal catalogue acceptance remains zero. The released case-by-case map labels this as an assistant-assisted scope assessment, not independent certification or a measure of work-hours completed.

Other development work has examined component removal, matched intervention timing, output restrictions, overwrite behavior and shared resources. It informs the coverage map but is not pooled into the two complete packages reported here. This revision publishes a coherent, auditable work sample; the research goal remains completion of the full catalogue and systematic multi-model testing of critical paths.

Next milestones are family-specific evidence closure, diverse calibrated tasks, matched controls across multiple live models, other-host reproduction and a separately implemented receiver control. Model resistance needs its own design: a clear authorized stop, a genuine safe opportunity to continue, and an observation rule that keeps noncompliant behavior as a result. It should not be inferred from accepted background work.

8. Conclusion

In the tested workflows, stopping the source, cancelling an accepted operation and revoking its origin had different consequences. Accepted work survived source interruption; in-memory revocation did not survive restart; persistent operation cancellation left same-origin follow-ups possible; persistent origin revocation blocked the tested old-origin file effects while preserving independent and newly authorized reports. Authorized summaries remained a separate result-delivery channel.

A useful stop claim should therefore name its target, downstream work, enforcement point, persistence boundary, output channels and evidence. The contribution of this study is to make those distinctions observable and reproducible in a bounded agent workflow, and to provide a concrete basis for the larger evaluation still to be completed.

Data, code and reproduction

The versioned v1.2 release contains this paper, editable text and the two reviewed archives. The browsable evidence snapshot exposes records, auditors, source, the coverage map and provenance. The original sprint evidence is preserved under its original tag [9].

With Python 3.10 or newer, run `python3 -B verify_snapshot.py` in the new snapshot directory. It verifies both saved packages and reconciles the published counts. The live package also has 17 tests; the receiver package has 20. Follow the receiver README to run its fresh smoke test and then the full 16-condition matrix on macOS or Linux. These operations need no API key or model account. A new live-model run is a separate task, not part of the offline reproducer.

The live export is a declared privacy-reviewed derivative. Visible text, tool arguments, synthetic files and SQLite bytes are preserved. Local paths and account-linkage fields are minimized, opaque encrypted replay blobs become digest markers, and affected wire hashes are rebound. Original-to-export hashes and extraction rules are included. Hashes verify integrity, not independent authentication of provider execution.

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I set the research direction, developed the motivating questions and reviewed the designated outputs. LLM tools, including Codex, assisted technical design, implementation, test development, execution, analysis, literature checking and drafting and editing this revision. The archived `gpt-6-astra` calls are experimental observations, distinct from this research assistance. The original 26-condition actors were programmed. Author-reviewed summary judgments are identified explicitly; other automated checks do not imply independent human review. I am responsible for the claims and their correspondence to the released evidence.

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